



fiction
feelings

Humans have this strange quirk of enjoying through fictions . . . being 'frightened' during of hide-and-seek, being 'tantalised' by a description of a long-lingering kiss in a poem, being 'upset' by the deceptive actions of a character in a soap opera.

We can experience the heartbreak of a character in a movie – but at a safe distance that turns it from heartbreak into a feeling we can enjoy.



There are many examples of art changing the course of history, advancing revolutions, bringing some people to tears and horrifying conservative people.

Art can have a tremendous effect on the world, which is why dictators have been so eager to lock artists up or employ them as propagandists.

but art is **effective**
because
it is

safe

You can read a novel and experience the horrors of war, the pain of prison or the beauty of deep love – but you don't have to endure the real-world consequences of those experiences.

You can shut the book. You can leave the gallery. You can stop dancing, close your eyes, exit the movie theater.

You can go away and you can get back to your normal life.

But you can take with you some memory of the experiences you had and that can change you.

ART IS A SIMULATOR

Think of a flight simulator, which is what I practise in. You have all the experiences of the plane, but you never leave the ground and the feelings feel real. You feel elated when you take off successfully and you sweat anxiety as you try to bring the plane in for a tidy landing.

What would the name for feelings of that kind be? Artificial feelings? Virtual feelings?

Fiction feelings?



What's the point of fiction feelings?

They alert you to the range of feelings you are of having. They enrich your feelings repertoire you something about other possible worlds: the might want to be in, and those you might want

They tell you those things in advance of ever experiencing them . . . so you have a repertoire of feelings 'fictional worlds' in your mind. And in these worlds you are allowed to take the consequences seriously and non-seriously as you want.

The level of seriousness is entirely up to you.



REAL ("HAS CONSEQUENCES YOU CAN'T ESCAPE")	FICTION ("OF NO INESCAPABLE CONSEQUENCE")
WAR	A POEM ABOUT WAR
NOT HAVING SHOES	NOT HAVING SHOE-TASSELS
FINDING OUT ABOUT YOUR REAL FATHER	FINDING OUT ABOUT DARTH VADER

(Sometimes we get so attached to fictional w they become our reality, and they are no long and harmless. For instance, when many peop in a fiction and start adjusting their expectat behaviour as though it is true, thereby bringi being. Or when a large part of someone's li place in a fictional game and the developmer game truly impact them. These fictional world like reality to us, and then we make fictiona about those, virtualisations of virtualisatio virtualisations of those – until everyone has where it all began. (Conspiracy theories are games gone wrong.))

